installations for electronic surveillance.[48] The United States reportedly has plans to use the Cocos as a base for drones to monitor sea traffic in the region, an action which the Chinese certainly would perceive as directed against them. Proposals have also been made in Australia to allow the Indian Navy to use the facilities on the Cocos.

China's long-term plans for its presence in the Indian Ocean are still unclear, especially as to whether there will be more ports and if those will actually be used by the Chinese military. But the fact that China is now there, in all probability to stay, has prompted India to upgrade its Indian Ocean fleet and to co-operate with other countries in the region. Although the situation in the Indian Ocean is nowhere near as worrisome as in the South and East China Seas, there can be no doubt that it is about to become a new focal point in the cold war that few want to talk about but that everyone knows is already a reality.

Some Western scholars have dismissed the notion that there is a new 'Great Game' being played out in the region.[49] But, as Colonel Stuart Kenny at the Australian Defence College in Canberra points out, there is indeed a New Great Game 'founded on historic mistrust and current competition'.[50] It has to do with border disputes in the Himalayas, the competition for influence in Nepal, Bhutan, and Myanmar, cross-border insurgencies, the sharing of water resources, and strategic rivalries in the Indian Ocean. And this time, it is not between Imperial Russia and the British Empire, but, after a long, complicated, and often violent history, between an independent India and China, a communist-ruled country that has risen from famine, chaos, and anarchy to become the world's new economic superpower.